



PROGRESS REPORT

Southern Africa: progress report, September 2025 – September 2026

Edition of 2026-09-09 · compiled by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository

Compiled 2026-09-09 by Claude Opus from the documents in the Corpus repository. Sections run from the region's institutions outwards to what funds them. Each opens with a movement ledger comparing the position at the start and end of the period, which runs to the date of issue rather than to the last month's close.

SUMMARY OF THE PERIOD · INSTITUTIONS AND MANDATES · INSTRUMENTS AND HARMONISATION ·
SHARED SYSTEMS AND INFRASTRUCTURE · COORDINATION AND COLLABORATION · CAPACITY AND INCLUSION · FINANCE
· WHERE THE RECORD IS THIN

Of 45 bodies, instruments and systems on this place's ledger, 24 changed position between 2025-09-01 and 2026-09-09, 9 did not, 10 carry no stated baseline, and 2 are **Not held** at both ends.

Shape check, run before the comparison: 66 sources for this place in the window – 13 in the earlier half (2025-09 to 2026-03), 53 in the later (2026-04 to 2026-09). The earlier half of the window is thin: this is a shorter comparison wearing a longer label, and the movement below rests mostly on the later half.

Movement values. *Advanced* — a system entered service, a stage was completed or an instrument was made. *Stalled* — a stated target passed without delivery. *Regressed* — an instrument was withdrawn or neutralised, or a measured position worsened. *Closed* — the programme ended. *No change* — the position at both ends is the same. *Baseline not held* — the base carries no position at the start of the period, so no movement can be stated. A value may carry a qualifying clause after a comma, as in *Advanced, slipped*.

Summary of the period

On 2026-07-27 the SADC-RTGS [took a second settlement currency](#), having settled in rand alone since 2013; on 2026-07-30 the region's central bank governors [approved regional frameworks](#) on cybersecurity, climate risk and cross-border crisis management. Both are the work of one institution, the Committee of Central Bank Governors.

The community's own digital instruments did not move: the Digital Transformation Strategy remains the [draft tabled to ministers on 12 October 2022](#), and the [2012 infrastructure master plan](#) reaches its horizon in 2027 with no revision on file.

Cross-border capacity was added by operators: a fibre corridor [carrying traffic from 2026-07-06](#), a subsea system [announced on 2025-09-24](#). Where regional coordination is documented over the period, it is COMESA's rather than SADC's, across an overlapping membership.

Institutions and mandates

Regional collaboration

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-09	MOVEMENT
CRASA (Communications Regulators Association of Southern Africa)	Not held	The association opened its 2026/27 financial year with the first meeting of its Finance, Risk and Audit Committee, a two-day hybrid session in Maseru on 20 and 21 August 2026 hosted by the Lesotho Communications Authority, at which the committee and the secretariat reviewed financial and audit matters and assessed institutional risk across the association's regional programmes. No budget, audit opinion, risk register or programme list reaches the base from it. Its consumer and stakeholder policy committee held the financial year's first ordinary in-person meeting at Gaborone from 2 to 4 September 2026 to advance the 2026/27 workplan (2026-09)	ADVANCED
IDEA programme (Inclusive Digitalization in Eastern and Southern Africa)	US\$2.48bn approved in June 2024, phase 1 Angola, DR Congo and Malawi; no forum and no regional action plan	Phase I is Zambia, DR Congo, Malawi and Angola, with Eswatini, Tanzania and Madagascar preparing Phase II; a Strategic Action Plan and Digital Action Matrix for 2026-2027 agreed	ADVANCED
IDEA Project Steering Committee (COMESA)	Two meetings since the programme was approved in June 2024	Third meeting, reviewing implementation and risk with other regional communities, EACO, SAPOA, SATA and the World Bank	ADVANCED
SADC preparatory process for the ITU World Radiocommunication Conference 2027	No preparatory meeting on record	Closed at Luanda on 7 August 2026 with harmonised SADC Common Positions and Proposals on key WRC-27 agenda items; spectrum allocation for International Mobile Telecommunications was named the sensitive debate and the common position document is not published (2026-08)	ADVANCED
Southern African Development Community (SADC)	Baseline not held	Chaired by South Africa from the 46th Ordinary Summit at Durban on 17 August 2026, taking over from Zimbabwe, with digital security named among the incoming chair's strategic priorities alongside energy, water, industrialisation and regional infrastructure, and accelerated implementation of SADC Vision 2050 and the Regional Indicative Strategic Development Plan stated as the frame	ADVANCED
SADC Financial Inclusion Subcommittee	Strategy on Financial Inclusion and SME Access to Finance 2023-2028 under review; Financial Inclusion Information Portal launched (2024-02)	The February 2024 review is still the newest record held; no meeting, work plan or portal update since	NO CHANGE
Regional higher education data system	Did not exist	Agreement on a regional higher education data system was set as one of five immediate priorities at a regional vice-chancellors' strategic meeting in Johannesburg on 31 August 2026, alongside implementation priorities for the regional higher education strategy, a network model for a proposed regional university, better qualifications recognition and credit transfer, and flagship research and skills programmes tied to the region's industrialisation agenda. South Africa's higher education minister told the meeting the region must build its own computing capability, trusted datasets, African-language technologies and cybersecurity rather than rent intelligence from others, and set the test as students and academics having moved and data being shared by the June 2027 ministers' meeting rather than documents completed	BASELINE NOT HELD

The IDEA Project Steering Committee [met in Lusaka on 2026-07-30](#), its third meeting since the programme was approved in June 2024. COMESA describes it as the programme's principal policy, governance and oversight organ, and those attending were other regional economic communities, the ICT associations EACO, SAPOA and SATA, and the World Bank. A regional economic community, not a member state, holds oversight of these countries' digital foundations.

The SADC Financial Inclusion Subcommittee's [meeting of 19-20 February 2024](#), which reviewed the Strategy on Financial Inclusion and SME Access to Finance 2023-2028, is still the newest record the base holds of it.

CRASA is the region's association of ICT and postal regulators, and the base carries one item on it: a [secretariat post](#) recording attendance at a continental meeting in July 2026. Nothing it has produced is held, so no position can be stated at either end of the period.

The regulators' association's own year opened on process. It held the [first Finance, Risk and Audit Committee meeting of its 2026/27 year over two days in Maseru on 20 and 21 August](#), hosted by the Lesotho Communications Authority, reviewing financial and audit matters and assessing institutional risk across its regional programmes; no budget, audit opinion or programme list reaches the base from it, and its harmonised regulatory guidelines remain a row the base cannot state.

Instruments and harmonisation

Strategies, plans and policies

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-09	MOVEMENT
SADC Digital Transformation Strategy and Action Plan	Draft of 12 October 2022, unadopted	Still the 2022 draft with no adoption decision on record, though the Secretariat cited the strategy as an instrument it is implementing (2025-08)	NO CHANGE

Legislation and regulation

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-09	MOVEMENT
Digital platform governance toolkit (RIA/UNESCO)	Did not exist	Published with a five-part self-assessment checklist, eight legislative building blocks and a five-tier escalation ladder; no regulator adoption on record	ADVANCED
SADC Computer Crime and Cybercrime Model Law	In force as a model since November 2012, unrevised	Unchanged; no revision, successor or transposition record held	NO CHANGE
SADC Electronic Transactions and Electronic Commerce Model Law	In force as a model since November 2012, unrevised	Unchanged; no revision, successor or transposition record held	NO CHANGE

Data protection

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-09	MOVEMENT
SADC Data Protection Model Law	The 2012 model law, unrevised, with a modernisation consultancy tendered February 2022	Unchanged; no revised text and no outcome of the 2022 revision on record	NO CHANGE

Standards

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-09	MOVEMENT
Lilongwe Declaration on Collaborative Regulation	Did not exist	Adopted with six shared principles and seven areas of collaborative action; CRASA has not published the text (2026-08-05)	ADVANCED
Regional data governance harmonisation roadmap	A first regional workshop devoted to digital, held at Antananarivo in September 2025 on data governance and electronic commerce	Policymakers, regulators and technical experts from eight Southern African states worked towards a roadmap for harmonising data governance frameworks, at a workshop convened by a UN agency with a continental digital body and a member state ministry, working from a data governance toolkit and undertaking national self-assessments	ADVANCED
SADC One Network Area roaming framework	Reduced rates between Botswana and Namibia only (2024-08)	Six states applying harmonised tariffs, with cuts between 10% and 98.6%	ADVANCED

AI

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-09	MOVEMENT
COMESA regional AI strategy	Did not exist	Stakeholder consultation held under the World Bank-supported IDEA programme to inform the strategy and its action plan; no draft, drafter or adoption route published	ADVANCED
SADC Regional Artificial Intelligence Strategy and Regulatory Framework	BASELINE NOT HELD	Under development according to Malawi's ICT ministry (2026-06); no draft, adoption date or Secretariat document held; a regional workshop at Harare on data governance in the artificial-intelligence age, convened with the World Bank, a continental alliance and a United Nations agency, set out to harmonise member states' data policy for readiness	<i>Baseline not held</i>

The instruments that moved were made by central banks. Meeting at Ezulwini, the SADC Committee of Central Bank Governors' subcommittee on banking supervision and financial stability **finalised and approved** regional frameworks on cybersecurity, climate-related financial risk and cross-border crisis management. Central Bank of Eswatini governor Phil Mnisi **said single-country data no longer suffices** for regional stability, and urged supervisors to extend oversight to cloud hosting providers, payment processors, and artificial intelligence used in credit scoring and fraud detection.

The Botswana Communications Regulatory Authority **announced on 2026-03-13** that Botswana and five other member states — Malawi, Lesotho, Mozambique, Zambia and Zimbabwe — had reduced and harmonised roaming tariffs under the One Network Area framework, with reported cuts of between 10% and 98.6%.

The community's own instruments did not move. The Digital Transformation Strategy and Action Plan is the **draft of 12 October 2022**, with no adoption decision on record. The Regional Infrastructure Development Master Plan, **adopted in August 2012**, runs to 2027; with under two years to that horizon the base holds no revision, successor or implementation report.

Shared systems and infrastructure

Connectivity

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-09	MOVEMENT
Powertel-Paratus cross-border fibre corridor	Did not exist	Phase 1 live and carrying traffic, on a route to link Zimbabwe with Botswana, Zambia and South Africa	ADVANCED
SADC regional internet exchange point	No host selection process on record	BoFiNet of Botswana and one Zimbabwean company shortlisted; no award held in the eight months since	ADVANCED
SADC Regional Infrastructure Development Master Plan	In force since 2012, carrying the ICT sector plan for a Digital SADC	Unchanged, with under two years to its horizon; no revision or successor held	NO CHANGE
Regional connectivity indicators	BASELINE NOT HELD	Internet penetration 57.2%, 4G population coverage 79.2% and mobile penetration 95.2%, the last already past the regional target set for 2030 (2026-08)	Baseline not held
SADC shared satellite	BASELINE NOT HELD	A technical submission on orbital positions filed with the ITU and the radiocommunication sector met to secure the slot, with a working group created to assess financing mechanisms and payment model; the project is stated to be at an early stage and no cost, launch date or operator is held (2026-08)	Baseline not held

Technical Capacity

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-09	MOVEMENT
Seacom 2.0 subsea system	Did not exist	Announced with 48 fibre pairs across the Indian Ocean basin; no route, cost or in-service date on record	ADVANCED

Cybersecurity

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-09	MOVEMENT
SADC central-bank frameworks on cyber, climate risk and cross-border crisis management	In drafting by working groups led by Botswana and Zimbabwe	Finalised and approved, with supervision extended to cloud hosts and payment processors	ADVANCED
SADC Regional CIRT framework	A draft framework of September 2018, unpublished, with no regional incident-response capability operating	Unchanged; the 2018 draft is still the newest record held	NO CHANGE

Data Exchange

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-09	MOVEMENT
Customs-to-customs data exchange roadmap	Did not exist	a joint roadmap and action plan for customs-to-customs data exchange adopted by five administrations — Malawi, Mozambique, South Africa, Zambia and Zimbabwe — at a three-day meeting in Pretoria hosted by the South African revenue service	ADVANCED

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-09	MOVEMENT
COMESA Digital Information Knowledge and Collaboration Platform	Did not exist	The secretariat has invited technical and financial proposals from eligible firms to develop the platform under contract reference CS/CC/06/(846-2026), with the minimum technical requirements set out in terms of reference annexed to the request. No budget, timetable, award or scope beyond the title reaches the base	BASELINE NOT HELD
One-stop border posts and digitised border systems	BASELINE NOT HELD	A chairship priority tying one-stop border posts to the corridor trip monitoring system that integrates transport, immigration and customs data, to online permitting and operator accreditation, to one member's electronic visa and travel authorisation, and to a proposed regional tourism visa, with progress to be measured in border-crossing times reduced rather than agreements signed	<i>Baseline not held</i>
Regional customs-to-customs data exchange roadmap	Did not exist	Customs administrations from five countries - Malawi, Mozambique, South Africa, Zambia and Zimbabwe - adopted a roadmap and action plan for customs-to-customs data exchange at a three-day meeting in Pretoria ending 26 August 2026, hosted by the South African revenue service and attended by the regional secretariat, to exchange trade information before consignments reach the border so that documentation and risk assessment happen earlier, phased from priority corridors and building on links already running between Zambia and Malawi and between Zambia and Zimbabwe	BASELINE NOT HELD
SADC Agricultural Information Management System	BASELINE NOT HELD	Member-state readiness under assessment with the FAO and the EU; no platform, membership or timetable held	<i>Baseline not held</i>

Digital Identity and CRVS

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-09	MOVEMENT
SADC cross-border digital-ID and eKYC framework	A South Africa-Lesotho verification pilot, no regional framework	Federated framework announced for all 16 member states; no build, budget or launch date on record in the year since	ADVANCED

Digital Payments and Fintech

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-09	MOVEMENT
COMESA Digital Retail Payments Platform	Did not exist	Piloting between Malawi and Zambia, targeting settlement costs under 3% of value against about 8%	ADVANCED
SADC-RTGS	Settling in rand alone since 2013; 15 of 16 members participating	Second settlement currency live; more than 80 banks, R250.7bn settled a month	ADVANCED
Settlement currencies in the SADC-RTGS	One, the rand (since 2013)	Two, rand and kwanza; pula and metical named next, four more weighing onboarding by end-2027	ADVANCED
TCIB cross-border retail payment scheme	A South Africa-Botswana commitment of late 2024, no corridor live	Botswana corridor live through one bank, First Capital Bank Botswana	ADVANCED

National statistics

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-09	MOVEMENT
SADC ICT Observatory	Named since at least 2018 as the destination for regional ICT indicators, with no published output held	Still assembling its inputs; the draft SADC Regional ICT Facts and Figures Report and proposed 2030 broadband indicators under review, and MoUs on indicator-data sharing between national statistics offices, ministries and regulators not yet in place (2025-08)	NO CHANGE

Use of satellite data

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-09	MOVEMENT
AgriWatch regional monitoring dashboard	Did not exist	A dashboard integrating Earth-observation products for crop-cycle, rangeland-health and rainfall monitoring, with training workshops, shared practice and case studies for government, academic, private-sector and community users across six southern African states	ADVANCED

The SADC-RTGS [admitted the Angolan kwanza on 2026-07-27](#), the first currency added since 2013 and the second it settles in. Fifteen of the sixteen members participate through [more than 80 banks, and the system settles R250.7bn a month](#). The SARB's [payments head](#) named the Botswana pula and the Mozambican metical as next, and a SARB spokesperson [told Central Banking](#) that Mauritius, Tanzania, Zambia and Zimbabwe are weighing onboarding, potentially by the end of 2027 — intent attributed to the system's operator, not decisions by those central banks.

Retail settlement moved on a smaller scale. TCIB [activated its South Africa-Botswana corridor](#) in March 2026, through a single bank. COMESA's Digital Retail Payments Platform, [launched on 2025-10-10](#), is piloting between Malawi and Zambia against a target of under 3% of transaction value, from a stated average of about 8%.

The systems SADC would own are earlier. The cross-border digital-ID and eKYC framework [announced in August 2025](#) with Co-Develop and FinMark Trust covers all 16 member states on paper and follows a South Africa-Lesotho pilot; a year on, the base has no build, budget or launch date for it. The regional internet exchange point stood at a [two-bidder shortlist](#) — BoFiNet of Botswana and one Zimbabwean company — on 2025-11-27, with no award in the eight months since.

Capacity that arrived was commercial: the Powertel-Paratus corridor's first phase [went live on 2026-07-06](#), and Seacom [announced a 48-fibre-pair Indian Ocean system](#) on 2025-09-24 with no route, cost or in-service date on record.

One regional system entered the record as a procurement rather than a build: the COMESA secretariat has [gone to market for a Digital Information Knowledge and Collaboration Platform under contract CS/CC/06/\(846-2026\)](#), with the technical requirements in annexed terms of reference and no budget, timetable or award published.

Coordination and collaboration

Innovation ecosystem

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-09	MOVEMENT
Injini Southern Africa AI edtech programme	Did not exist	An eight-month accelerator supporting twelve teams across Southern Africa building affordable AI tools for local classrooms, with seed funding for the five strongest projects at the end	ADVANCED

The only regional innovation instrument to move is an [edtech accelerator for twelve teams](#).

Capacity and inclusion

Research institutions

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-09	MOVEMENT
Research and development spending against the regional target	BASELINE NOT HELD	No member state has reached the regional target of 1% of GDP, or the continental target of 1.5% (2026-08)	Baseline not held

Access to services

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-09	MOVEMENT
Adults financially included in SADC	119 million, 77% of adults (2024-02), against 57% in 2011	No later figure held; the 2024 survey is still the newest	NO CHANGE

Digital divides

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-09	MOVEMENT
COMESA Regional Digital Inclusion Strategy	Did not exist	In drafting under the World Bank-supported IDEA programme, with consultation on affordable connectivity and devices, skills gaps, accessibility and digital trust; no draft, drafter or adoption date published	ADVANCED

Financial inclusion is the only capacity measure the region carries, and it did not move over the window: [119 million adults, 77% of the total, on a 2024 survey that is still the newest held](#), against 57% in 2011. No later regional figure has been published, so the twelve months add nothing to what was known at their start.

Finance

New investments

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-09	MOVEMENT
Botswana Tech Fund	Did not exist	First phase of GBP 5m against a GBP 50m target, backing pre-seed and growth companies across Southern Africa	ADVANCED

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	AT 2025-09-01	AT 2026-09-09	MOVEMENT
UK science and technology accelerator programme	BASELINE NOT HELD	A three-year programme of up to GBP2.5m out to expressions of interest, covering artificial intelligence and emerging technologies and digital access and inclusion alongside climate, energy, health and space, with a primary focus on South Africa and a first-year focus on Zimbabwe and Zambia	Baseline not held

The Botswana Tech Fund [announced its launch on 2026-04-21](#) with a first phase of GBP 5m against a GBP 50m target and a mandate across Southern Africa; the figures are the fund's own, from its launch release.

The region's headline inclusion figure did not move. The newest measurement the base holds is [February 2024's](#) — 119 million adults, 77% of the regional total, against 57% in 2011. The period cannot say whether the payment rails that did move have changed it, and the base holds no regional financing instrument or capacity programme of SADC's own.

Where the record is thin

BODY, INSTRUMENT OR SYSTEM	WHAT WOULD SETTLE IT	LAST PROBED
CRASA harmonised regulatory guidelines	A CRASA work programme, guideline or annual report; the base holds one secretariat post and nothing the association has produced; probed 2026-08-05: an April 2026 summit declaration located, not fetched	2026-08-05
SADC regional digital skills programme	A SADC Secretariat programme document or a member-state report of one; the region's capacity work is entirely unheld; probed 2026-08-05: no dedicated regional skills programme found; the nearest is the SADC ICT Observatory	2026-08-05

Five named objects carry no position at either end: a SADC data-protection instrument, a regional AI strategy or position, CRASA's harmonised guidelines, an operational incident-response capability under the supervisory frameworks approved in July 2026, and a regional digital skills programme.

Each was searched on 2026-08-05. Four returned named documents, none of them in the base and none cited above; they are queued for acquisition. On the evidence of the search these are gaps in this record rather than in the region's activity, and the thin sections above should be read that way until the documents are held.

Two further absences have no object to chase. The base holds nothing on Chinese, Indian or Gulf engagement with the region's digital infrastructure, in a period whose two documented external partners were the European Union and the World Bank. And every regional instrument on this ledger is visible through a member state, a central bank, an operator or a lender rather than through SADC's own published record.

ABOUT THIS DOCUMENT

EDITION	2026-09-09
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